

the condition, social or physical, of the countries with which he deals; and seizes in each instance some characteristic aspect, or feature, for notice (*e.g.* the haughty independence of Moab, the tall and handsome physique of the Ethiopians, the local and other peculiarities of Egypt, the commerce and colonies of Tyre).

13, 1—14, 23. On Babylon. In this prophecy the Jews are represented as in *exile*, held in thralldom by the Babylonians, but shortly to be released in consequence of the capture of Babylon by the Medes (13, 17). C. 13 describes the mustering of the assailing forces on the mountains, the terror of their approach, the capture and sack of the city, the fewness of the survivors (*v.* 12), and the desolation which will mark thereafter the site of Babylon. 14, 1—2 states the reason of this, viz. because the time has arrived for Israel to be released from exile: "For Jehovah will have compassion upon Jacob, and *will again choose Israel*, and settle them in their own land." 14, 3—20 the prophet provides Israel with an ode of triumph, to be sung in the day of its deliverance, depicting, with extreme beauty of imagery, and not without a delicate under-current of irony, the fall of the Babylonian monarch from his proud estate: *vv.* 21—23 he reasserts the irretrievable ruin of the great city.

The situation presupposed by this prophecy is not that of Isaiah's age. The Jews are not warned, as Isaiah (39, 6) might warn them, against the folly of concluding an alliance with Babylon, or reminded of the disastrous consequences which such an alliance might entail; nor are they threatened, as Jeremiah threatens them, with impending exile: they are represented as *in exile*, and as about to be delivered from it (14, 1—2). It was the office of the prophet of Israel to address himself to the needs of his own age, to announce to his contemporaries the judgments, or consolations, which arose out of the circumstances of their own time, to interpret for them their own history. To base a promise upon a condition of things *not yet existent*, and without any point of contact with the circumstances or situation of those to whom it is addressed, is alien to the genius of prophecy. Upon grounds of analogy the prophecy 13, 2—14, 23 can only be attributed to an author living towards the close of the exile and holding out to his contemporaries the prospect of release from Babylon, as Isaiah held out to *his* contemporaries the prospect of deliverance from